

device around, click, send an MMS. She likes them; that was too easy. "Don't forget to bring the sweets, we have guests tonight," she says. "Forget? I never forget! Talk to you later." You can't believe you forgot about the sweets! No more chances; a tap lets you write down a note, set a reminder alarm—forget the sweets and sleep on the couch!

Science fiction? Not really, this device—the Nokia 7700—is the convergence

of a cell phone, an FM radio, an MP3 player, a PDA, a camera, a video player-cum-recorder and a TV set; it's due out next year.

Convergence in the communication arena is going through interesting times. Sales of PDAs are dropping, cell phones are on the rise, and both of them are stomping and vying for your pocket space. We thus have such devices as the Sony Ericsson P900 in one corner and Handspring's Treo 600 in the other. The former is the phone industry's answer to the PDA, the latter the PDA's answer to the cell phone. Whichever way you look at it, the lines separating the contestants are blurred: like it or not, your cell phone and PDA will soon become one, convergence to the max.

While a convergence of technology serves as foundation, it will be services that draw customers in and keep them hooked. We thus have a coming together of services: from the PC to other devices. You must have noticed the Orange hoardings, advertising the fact that you can access your Hotmail account via the cellular service. Microsoft is taking its messenger services places, mostly to your phone. Tie-ups to bring you instant

messages, e-mail, the weather, news, stock quotes... the strategy is two-pronged: get market share via pure services such as the Orange/Hotmail offering, or via such hardware-cum-software platforms as SPOT (Smart Personal

Object Technology) and Smartphones.

SPOT is a US and Canada-centric idea which has Microsoft and FM broadcasters casting a DirectBand network over major cities. The network will be supported by SPOT-enabled devices such as wristwatches. The idea is to offer access to continually updated content on news, traffic, weather, stocks, sports, instant messaging; and features such as automatic time adjustment based on location, customisable watch faces, chronometer, calendar and alarm functions. Microsoft and National Semiconductor have devised a SPOT chipset, along with a special OS to address the power, size and cost challenges that a wristwatch offers. The chipset is an ARM7 CPU along with SRAM and ROM, and a radio chip in the form of a 100 MHz RF receiver.

Ever competitive, the software behemoth is eyeing the Symbian success with disdain, and has been trying to get its own Smartphone initiative off the ground for some time now. Sierra Wireless has attracted quite a buzz with its Voq Smartphone. The Voq is a tri-band phone powered by a 200 MHz Intel PXA262 XScale processor, supporting GSM voice networks and GPRS data networks. It includes 32 MB of RAM

(16 MB of which is available to users, to run applications) and has 48

MB of Flash memory (20 MB available to store data

and software), plus an SD/MMC slot for removable

media. It will run the Windows Mobile

operating system, and will

sport a 220 x 176 pixel screen, a joystick and a flip-open

QWERTY keyboard

for user input. Voq users will be able to access e-mail, browse the

Web, send instant messages, make phone calls, play games, and run MS-Office type applications.

Another match-up attracts attention—this one between makers of consumer electronics and PC companies. The Dells and the Samsungs of the world are ready to go at each other over convergence.

PC sales are slowing down to an annual growth rate of single-digit percentile points, CRT monitors are all but

dead (a fate coming soon to a country near you). LCDs are the new chic, PVR is hot, broadband is hesitant but interested, things are stirring up. Where is the fight? The CE guys see the TV as the centre of digital entertainment, the PC guys... well, the PC. Everyone seems to agree that CRTs are out, thin is in. Thus we have Plasma screens that work

as PC monitors and television sets, ditto LCDs. This is where the twain part. PC manufacturers, perhaps for evident reasons, are warming up to solutions such as Microsoft's Media Centre, while the boys from CE are tooling TV sets with hard disks, Ethernet, USB, FireWire ports, enabling them to talk Bluetooth and WiFi, to transparently connect to the Internet, to record favourite programs straight to DVDs... Samsung Electronics is convinced of the evangelical benefits of the TV: in a CNet News.com interview, their Executive VP, Eric Kim, was quoted as saying, "We believe TV will become another digital centre for the home. Until now, the digital centre was the computer, but while the digital experience of the PC is great for certain things, it's limited... With a TV, you're leaning back, very relaxed. You may have friends or family with you. It's a very different experience... The time is coming when we'll see a shift from a PC-centric orientation to a TV-centric orientation. That's our bet, and we're investing a lot of money behind it."

Meanwhile, tunnels have been dug under safe havens, and dents have been made in the traditional markets of the consumer electronics giants. Sony, for example, was never in worse shape,

Info Sony, Sharp, Pioneer, and Kenwood are working together on a new line of stereo systems with Ethernet ports that can download music directly from the Internet—without requiring a PC



The Nokia 7700 — also a cell phone